



Periscope live tweet

Periscope now allows external devices and third-party apps to connect and broadcast on the service. <http://dgit.in/PerisTwitter>



NASA's origami robots

Mars Rover is having a tough time handling sharp corners; NASA's new origami robots can. <http://dgit.in/NASAOorigami>

Bazaar

Nikon D3400

A neat incremental upgrade

The Nikon D3400 is an incremental upgrade to its predecessor, the D3300. It houses the same, 24.2 MP image sensor that powers the D3300, along with the EXPEED 4 image processor which is a generation old now. That, though, does not deter the D3400 from still delivering best-in-class colour and ISO performance, without having changed much about its build, operations and photography performance.

Colours produced by the Nikon D3400 look crisp and punchy, and thanks to good dynamic range, the camera manages to retain highlights and shadows with proficiency. Saturation levels are well balanced, and the accuracy of tones ensure a fairly neutral balance between warmer and cooler shades that most would like. For instance, dominant red tones are not over-emphasised, and predominant yellow shades retain the accuracy of shade without affecting the overall colour tone of the composition.

RAW files are particularly impressive for its category, leaving you with ample room to tweak highlights to save dark areas, adjust fine details and post process photos well. The Nikon D3400 does tend to slightly overdo sharp edges, which combined by the good contrast levels may look a tad bit too vivid. When shooting under contrasting light conditions, you can underexpose subjects to balance highlights to remove clipping, and adjust exposure in post-processing to provide ample light in darker subject areas without compromising on minute details, colours and image noise.

However, you do encounter slight softening of sharp edges when you export your RAWs to JPEGs, owing to lossy compression. Despite good production of fine details, subject edges tend to lose sharpness, and shooting directly in JPEG also reveals this slight weakness. This is particularly noticeable when you shoot sharp objects in clean environments, although the vividness of colours and clean noise performance ensures that you somewhat make up for it. Low light photography is as good as it can get in this segment, surpassing cameras from competitors.

The automatic ISO performance is good, adjusting well with the available light within frames to keep it as low as possible even in low light. Thankfully, there is minimal colour



distortion even at ISO levels above 3200, which also leave with the ability to post-process photos to salvage some details and colours. Invariance, as you would expect, is certainly unobtainable here, and produces unfavourable results if you attempt it.

The 11-point autofocus system, however, is a slightly weak link to an otherwise fine entry-segment DSLR. Although it does get the work done with decent subject locking and tracking, it is not the fastest, and slightly more expensive Nikon DSLRs with the Multi-CAM 4800DX with 39 focus points is what we sorely missed here. The central cross-type point aids fast lenses in shooting, and this gets the job done fairly well in well-lit situations. However, you do struggle a bit when you shoot in darker conditions, or while shooting in or at fast-moving subjects.

It also gets Bluetooth, which allows easy photo sharing with Nikon's Snapbridge app for Android and iOS. However, it sorely misses out on a swivelling LCD display, which is not even touchscreen - surprising exclusions from Nikon. Battery life is pretty good, with us obtaining nearly 1,000 stills and 85 minutes of 1080p video recording at 60 FPS. Everything taken into account, the Nikon D3400 is the best entry-segment DSLR to buy in India right now. That said, you may want to consider the Nikon D3300's dual-lens kit that sells for about the same price, for more versatility.

Souvik Das



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Specifications

Sensor: CMOS, 24.2 million effective pixels;
Viewfinder: Eye-level pentamirror, 95% frame coverage; **Shutter:** Electronically controlled vertical travel focal plane; **ISO sensitivity:** 100 to 25600 (native); **Autofocus:** Nikon Multi-CAM 1000, 11 focus points, 1 cross-type

Contact

Nikon India
Phone: 1-800-102-7346
Email: nindsupport@nikon.com
Website: www.nikon.co.in